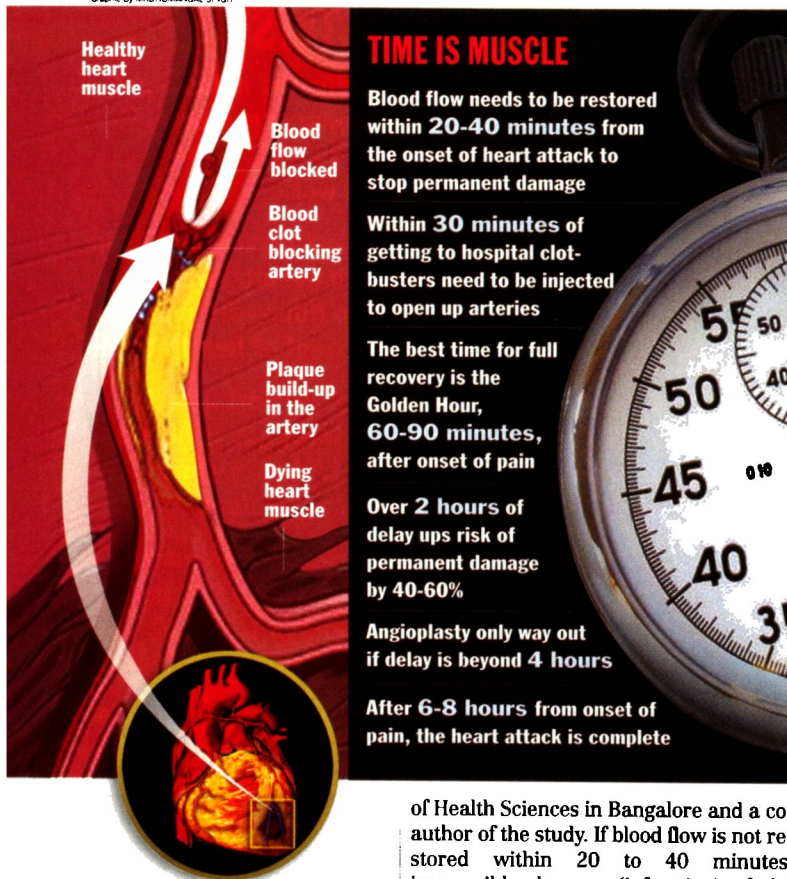


Graphic By MADHUMANGAL SINGH



WARNING SIGNS

Not everyone gets the classic Hollywood Heart Attack symptoms—chest pain and sweating.

ATYPICAL SYMPTOMS: Often there is pain in the shoulders, neck, jaw, upper abdomen, arms, choking and a sense of impending doom

MORE IN MEN: Dull ache, general discomfort, right-side chest discomfort, symptoms of indigestion

MORE IN WOMEN: Throat discomfort, pressing on the chest and also vomiting

of Health Sciences in Bangalore and a co-author of the study. If blood flow is not restored within 20 to 40 minutes, irreversible damage (infarction) of the heart begins to occur with possibility of sudden death due to heart-rhythm disturbance. The muscle continues to die for six to eight hours—the time by which the heart attack is usually “complete”.

As for Tewari, he had never seen people move so quickly or in such concerted manner before. As one nurse administered oxygen to help relieve his chest pain, others did an electrocardiogram (ECG) to assess his heart rhythm, yet another gave him an Aspirin to chew to improve the anti-clotting effect of the “thrombolysis” treatment, which came later. A flurry of blood test, chest X-ray, ECG and MRI scans followed. And before he had time to catch his breath, a thrombolytic drug was injected into his bloodstream. “Ideally the injection to dissolve the clot blocking the artery should be given as soon as possible—within one hour of getting the symptoms, and at the latest within six hours. It’s less effective as time

Graphic By PRASHANT CHAUDHARY



goes by,” points out Prabhakaran.

The study, conducted by a team of researchers led by Dr Denis Xavier of St John’s National Academy in Bangalore, tracked 20,937 patients in 89 hospitals across 50 cities at 30-day intervals for four years, until 2005. “We assessed clinical characteristics of patients,” says Xavier, “along with their socio-economic status, geographical location, transportation to hospitals, time from admission to treatment, key treatment patterns and modes of payment.” The results revealed a dangerous schedule: The average time taken for an Indian heart patient from onset of symptoms to hospital is 300 minutes or five hours. In comparison, it takes about 140-170 minutes for patients in developed countries to get to a hospital. While 38 per cent Indians reach a hospital in less than four hours, 25 per cent take four to 12 hours and a substantial 35 per cent take more than 12 hours to get medical help. “If you wait 12 hours when you are having a heart attack, the damage is basically done and it’s too late to benefit from all the new

33% of heart attack symptoms occur without